

Problem Session: Constituency Tests

Reading: Andrew Carnie (2013), *Syntax: A Generative Introduction*, 3rd ed., Chapter 3

Reference. A *constituent* is a group of words that function together as a unit. If a string is a constituent, we expect it to behave as a unit. Carnie gives four tests:

Replacement / Pronominalization	Replace the string with a single word (<i>he, him, it, there, then, so, do so</i>).
Stand-alone	Use the string alone as the answer to a question (sentence-fragment test).
Movement	Move the string as a unit: clefting (<i>It was ... that ...</i>), pseudo-clefting (<i>... is/are what ...</i>), preposing (fronting the string, e.g. <i>Your elder sister, I can't stand</i>), postposing, passive.
Coordination	Conjoin the string with a similar string of the same category (<i>and, or, but</i>).

Two rules for using the tests. (i) Keep the meaning as close as possible to the original sentence. A test that produces a grammatical sentence with a different meaning does not count. (ii) Always use **at least two** different tests, because one test alone can give a false result.

Note on terms. *preposing* means fronting a string to the beginning of the clause, and *pseudoclefting* means the *X is what ...* frame.

1. Warm-up: Which test is it?

For each pair, (i) name the test that was applied, and (ii) give the string that the test shows to be a constituent, with its category (NP, VP, PP, AdjP, AdvP, CP).

- (a) Mary put the vase on the shelf. → Mary put the vase there.
- (b) The students read the article about syntax. → It was the article about syntax that the students read.
- (c) A: Where did you leave the keys? B: Under the sofa.
- (d) My neighbor fixed the old bicycle. → The old bicycle was fixed by my neighbor.
- (e) I met the new teacher and her husband at the party.

2. Constituent or not?

Decide whether the bracketed string is a constituent. Apply **at least two** tests and write out the test sentences with your judgments (* or ✓). If the string is a constituent, give its category. If two tests disagree, say which result you trust and why.

- (a) The student loved [his phonology readings].
- (b) The student loved [his phonology] readings.
- (c) [The student loved] his phonology readings.
- (d) Paul ate [at a really fancy restaurant].
- (e) Paul [ate at] a really fancy restaurant.
- (f) Paul [ate at a really fancy restaurant].

3. Constituency tests and ambiguity

The man killed the king with the knife.

- (a) Give a paraphrase for each of the two meanings.
- (b) For each sentence below, say which meaning(s) are still available. Explain your answer in terms of constituency.
 - (i) The man killed him with the knife.
 - (ii) It was the king with the knife that the man killed.
 - (iii) It was with the knife that the man killed the king.
 - (iv) A: What did the man do? B: Killed the king with the knife.

4. Phrasal verbs vs. prepositional verbs

Part A. The two sentences below look the same on the surface: V + *up* + NP.

- (1) He looked up the chimney.
- (2) He looked up the answer.

Apply each test to (1) and (2) and write the resulting sentences with judgments. Then say in which sentence *up* + NP is a constituent.

Test	(1) <i>looked up the chimney</i>	(2) <i>looked up the answer</i>
Preposing of <i>up</i> + NP		
Stand-alone (<i>up</i> + NP)		
<i>up</i> after the object NP		
Object replaced by <i>it</i>		

Part B. Using constituency tests, show that in (a) and (b) the preposition goes with the verb, not with the following NP.

- (a) He blew out the candle.
- (b) He turned off the light.

5. Challenge

Do the words in bold form a single constituent? That is, is there a constituent [Zoktay and Hilal dancing]? How do you know? Use all the tests available to you.

Zoktay and Hilal were seen by everyone at the concert **dancing**.